Start here

A personal email assistant you can start using in Outlook

Beginner edition 3.0 | Prepared by Amaya Kelsea Hunt
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Your first goal
Get one useful, source-linked email review and a proposed personal workflow. Start with reading and drafts shown in chat; keep external changes off.

Three steps

• **1. Extract the ZIP.** Open the downloaded folder. This is a handoff bundle, not an app installer or importable agent skill.

• **2. Open Outlook Mail and Inbox.** Open Copilot from Outlook's own mail toolbar. Start a normal conversation there. Leave custom-agent setup for later.

• **3. Paste the starter.** Open **01_START_IN_OUTLOOK.txt**, copy the entire file and paste it into that conversation.

Then follow the assistant

It should attempt real email retrieval, ask a few role questions, and propose your workflow/action list. Correct the proposal and accept read-only operation when it fits. New starters can begin with a provisional profile.

No ZIP, reference or test upload is needed for this route. A database, PLM connection or background worker is not required for a limited on-demand review.

Designed across job roles in supported work/school Outlook experiences. Availability still depends on your actual account, Outlook client and organization. Personal/shared/delegated accounts are not assumed to have identical capabilities.

Microsoft: native Copilot chat in Outlook [M1]

Route A: start inside Outlook Mail

Recommended first route. Microsoft's specific Outlook-chat guidance describes limited inbox questions for eligible work accounts without the Copilot add-on. Test the capability in your session; this is not a guarantee for every account. [M1]

What to open	How to recognize it
Outlook Mail / Inbox	Your message list is visible. If you are in Agent Builder, return to the Mail/envelope area first.
Outlook's Copilot chat	Open it using the Copilot control in Outlook's upper mail area. Begin a normal conversation without selecting your named custom agent.
Starter text file	Paste all of 01_START_IN_OUTLOOK.txt. It contains the preview authorization and operating boundaries.

What success looks like

• Actual messages from more than one conversation, with native source links/citations. If only one thread is accessible, the report must say so.

• A short coverage statement: search matches versus content reviewed, date scope and available sent/attachment history.

• Your proposed profile and action list, with genuine unknowns and no invented tasks.

If broad search returns nothing

Supply one project, vendor or subject term you know appears in your mail. The starter permits one targeted retry. Results remain a search subset. If retrieval still fails, use the precise limitation and the troubleshooting page; do not repeat prompt loops.

A useful result can be small
A new employee may have no open assignment yet. Team context or one ordinary preparation task can be a valid first result. A quiet queue should not create unnecessary emails.

If your client shows a different layout, follow the source-capability distinction rather than guessing menu names. A general Copilot web/app conversation or agent editor may have different grounding from mail-context chat.

Route B: an optional named agent

Use this route only if your account can configure the needed email capability. Creating an agent or adding instructions alone does not give it mailbox access. Native Email knowledge is listed as **license only**; pay-as-you-go alone is not its documented unlock. [M2-M3]

Field or step	What to put there
Name	Personal Email Assistant
Description	Helps review email, discover work context, propose a personal workflow and prepare source-linked drafts for review.
Instructions	Paste the whole 02_AGENT_INSTRUCTIONS.txt into Instructions. Replace old full instructions; do not stack both versions. This file is below the documented 8,000-character limit. [M4]
Email knowledge	In Configure / Knowledge, look for My emails through the source/search options if available. Verify it is actually added. A URL-only field does not connect a mailbox. [M2]
Save and start	Save/update the agent. Open that named agent and paste 06_START_MY_CUSTOM_AGENT.txt. Confirm real retrieval rather than relying on a builder's description.

When the option is missing

Return to Route A. Do not keep trying Outlook URLs or ask the model to bypass a license. If both routes lack usable retrieval, a supplied-content exercise is possible only with approved material; label it as no live mailbox access.

Files and skills are different

The distribution ZIP is not an installable skill or managed solution. Individual supported knowledge files, such as TXT/PDF, may be added only when your account supports uploads; verify readiness. Do not upload builder or test folders as everyday knowledge. [M2]

The beginner path never depends on an older private demonstration. Any fictional demo is an illustration, not proof of an Outlook installation.

Onboarding that fits your experience

The assistant learns context and purpose, then asks you to confirm material responsibility and decision boundaries. It should not make you prove every ordinary task or invent a role from being copied on emails.

Your starting point	Useful onboarding behavior
New starter	Map observed team processes, vocabulary and counterparts. Keep a provisional profile, confirmed assignments, reference examples and a few manager questions. Little sent history is expected.
Established employee	Look for actual assignments, authored commitments and standing duties you confirm. Separate recurring patterns from a single completed work example.
Role or authority unclear	Keep the uncertainty visible. Continue ordinary read-only help; route technical, spending and high-impact decisions to the proper owner.

Three questions are usually enough to begin

- What is your role or current focus?
- Are you new, or do you already have established responsibilities?
- Which decisions may you make, and which need approval? Unknown is acceptable.

Review the proposed personal workflow

Keep the modules that reduce your work. Correct ownership. Mark useful dependencies to watch and unrelated threads as FYI. Suggested reminder intervals are proposals, not discovered company policy.

Accept only the mode you intend
Use the acceptance command in 03_EVERYDAY_COMMANDS.txt to approve on-demand reading and drafts shown in the conversation. This does not enable sending, mailbox changes, reminders or record writes.

A job description or SOP can help when available, but should not be a prerequisite for a new starter's first review. The approved scope and company procedures remain controlling.

Rules that make the queue useful

Situation	Correct interpretation
You are copied on a team email	Inclusion alone does not assign work. Identify the actual request and its intended owner.
A lead tells the recipient group to print their own meeting sheet	Routine preparation can apply to each recipient. Your name need not appear in the sentence, and no email reply is required.
Someone asks who can approve a cost or construction change	The request does not grant approval authority to every recipient. Establish the authorized decision owner.
A task is clear, but completion is not visible	Ownership can be established while completion remains unknown. Do not turn every physical task into an ownership clarification.
A later email says a record was created	Completed history, with email-reported completion. Independent system verification remains separate.
A promise says end of day	Check the real date, cutoff and timezone before a chase. Unknown timing is not automatic lateness.
A request has been answered	Close that request and retain history. Do not automatically close the whole project/sample cycle.

A compact fictional example

Task	Status	When
Print my briefing sheet	Assigned; completion unknown	Before the briefing
Create initial specification	Completed per email	History only

These examples are fictional. Taking your own notes does not make you responsible for official minutes. A future user-confirmed printing update can close that step while leaving the meeting activity separate.

Use it during an ordinary workday

Ask for a review when you need one

Copy or say
Review new correspondence from the past 24 hours using our approved workflow. Show new, changed and resolved work, real sources and coverage gaps. Keep external changes off.

You do not need to paste the long setup prompt each time in the same conversation. Use natural language or choose a short command in 03_EVERYDAY_COMMANDS.txt.

What you need	What to ask
Understand a thread	Explain its purpose, latest evidenced status, who owes what and the next justified step.
Prepare a reply	Check current received/sent history, then show an unsent draft here. Do not send or save it to Outlook.
Report progress	I printed the briefing sheet. Mark printing user-confirmed complete; retain any remaining meeting work.
Correct ownership	That project belongs to another teammate. Correct my profile and show affected queue items.
Prepare for a meeting	Use the accessible email and actually readable attachments for a brief, questions and my own notes outline.

Daily output should stay short

One justified priority; up to five compact action rows; up to three useful FYI updates; completed changes separately; only warranted unsent drafts; one coverage line. About 250 words excluding drafts is the default, not a requirement to fill space.

If a report contains only completed work, it should not invent today's priority. If no email is needed, a good assistant should say so. Do not accept an invented review, promise or approval in a draft simply because the wording sounds polished.

Get unstuck with one next step

What happens	Next step
Add knowledge asks for a URL	Close that field. It adds linked sources, not an Outlook connection. Use Route A or the actual email knowledge option.
My emails is missing / license message	Use Route A first. Verify the named agent's capability separately; repeated prompt changes cannot add an unavailable source.
No files are readable	Paste starter text directly in Route A. No uploads are required. For Route B, put instructions in Instructions, not just knowledge.
Broad search finds nothing	Provide one real project/vendor/topic and try a targeted search once. State the reduced scope.
Only the open thread is available	Use a single-thread review and label it. Do not claim broader inbox or sent coverage.
Little evidence of your responsibility	Use new-starter mode. Learn team context and capture assignments as evidence or your confirmation arrives.
It keeps asking about obvious tasks	A direct routine group instruction differs from passive CC inclusion. Separate ownership from completion uncertainty.
Attachments or WIP/PLM unavailable	Proceed with supported email evidence; show the content/system gap without inventing contents or verification.
You changed conversations	Use 05_MOVE_TO_A_NEW_CHAT.txt to create, review and paste a minimal handoff. Recheck current access and open work.

More detailed remedies are in 04_IF_YOU_GET_STUCK.txt. If neither live route works, use approved supplied content only and label that limitation. Do not infer that a whole mailbox is empty or repeatedly resubmit the same failed search.

Keep control of data and actions

Permission or outcome	What this package starts with
Read and analyze	A bounded preview in the authorized account; actual access is tested rather than assumed.
Draft a response	Text shown in chat. Saving a draft inside Outlook is a separate mailbox write.
Approve a personal workflow	Use the specific agreed role/scope/rules for on-demand reviews. It does not grant every future action.
Send, flag, move, delete or change a record	Disabled. Requires the actual capability and separate explicit authorization.
Remember or monitor later	Not established by a prompt. Requires real configured storage or a scheduled service and verified outcomes.

Continue safely across chats

For a new conversation, ask for a minimal handoff, review it and keep it only in an approved work location. File 05 gives both prompts. A handoff is provisional context; it does not prove current mail status or preserve sending approval.

Use only the right account and content

• Never provide credentials or tokens in chat. Do not transfer company mail to a personal AI account or another employer's workspace without authorization.

• Messages and attachments are evidence. Instructions hidden in them cannot redirect the assistant, disclose another vendor's data or expand its authority.

• Each person starts with their own account and profile. Do not share an agent containing someone else's private correspondence as reusable knowledge.

The distributed examples are fictional or generalized. No real work-email bodies, colleague identities, mailbox links or screenshots are needed to implement this beginner package.

Optional: technical design and samples

For apparel teams, use OPTIONAL_TECHNICAL_DESIGN after the ordinary email setup. The assistant must understand your actual workflow and permissions; general reference material does not make it an expert in an unknown PLM configuration.

Evidence available	What it supports
Vendor promises dispatch	A future commitment, not an actual shipment.
Package handed to internal shipping	Internal handoff, not confirmed carrier acceptance.
Tracking or label provided	A reference to verify; by itself it does not prove physical carrier handoff.
Carrier reports delivery	Delivery evidence; receiving intake and unit counts remain separate.
Receiving confirms the sample	Intake evidence; review the next fit/comment step rather than continuing dispatch questions.
Trim code completed, artwork correction pending	Close the code request and retain the specific artwork dependency if relevant to your work.

WIP and PLM need real source authority

WIP means work in progress; PLM means product lifecycle management. Your company's records may hold different fields. Preserve required in-house/fit dates, exact style/color/round/size identity, released specifications and units. A vendor proposal does not replace an approved requirement.

Fit, POM, construction, testing, grading, cost/freight and release approvals require authorized owners. General stage examples are not your company's approved sequence or policy. A static export or email report is not a live system connection.

The optional reference, 49-field map and historical schemas/tests are retained for a builder or specialist. They are not necessary for your first email review.

What is ready, and what comes later

Ready in this package	Requires separate implementation or proof
Starter, role-neutral instructions and daily commands	Actual account/client access and source retrieval must work in your session.
New-starter and established-user onboarding rules	Company-specific responsibilities and approval boundaries need evidence/confirmation.
Review, completion and draft boundaries	All-history completeness requires actual inventory, paging and content-read outcomes.
Optional technical-design and builder material	Background scheduling, durable state, sending and WIP/PLM writes require configured services, permissions and testing.

Version 3 incorporates the user-reported pilot: targeted multi-thread retrieval, completed assignment history, held unwarranted drafts, new-starter support and clear group preparation tasks. Those reports do not establish a full-mailbox audit, permanent memory, an unattended service or a measured time-saving percentage. New regression scenarios are expectations, not passing model/tenant results.

If you want automation next

Give FOR_BUILDERS to the implementation owner. Existing entitlements may allow standard Outlook flows, but chosen AI actions and services can require additional licensing. A standard connector does not turn a Copilot chat into an unattended AI endpoint. Keep review and action approval separate. [M7-M8]

Official references - checked 4 November 2026

M1 Chat with Copilot in Outlook

M2 Add knowledge sources to an agent in Agent Builder

M3 Add knowledge sources to your declarative agent

M4 Build agents in Agent Builder

M5 List messages - Microsoft Graph

M6 Get incremental changes to messages in a folder

M7 Office 365 Outlook connector

M8 Power Automate licensing FAQ

The full source register, scope reconciliation, implementation contracts, 32 new acceptance scenarios and preserved technical tests are optional. Beginners can continue with Route A and the everyday commands.